NOTICING CHANGES, SUPPORTING STUDENTS

A student well-being observation guide for educators

Purpose

This guide helps teachers notice changes that may indicate a student needs additional support. It is not a diagnostic checklist.

What should teachers observe?

Emotional changes
• Appearing persistently worried, sad, or irritable.
• Becoming unusually withdrawn.
• Showing a marked change in emotional expression.

Learning and participation
• A noticeable change in concentration or performance.
• Repeated difficulty starting or completing tasks.
• A sudden change in classroom participation.

Social changes
• Withdrawing from usual friendships.
• Repeated conflict with peers.
• Appearing isolated or reluctant to attend school.

These behaviors can have many explanations. A single observation does not establish that a student has a psychological difficulty.

What can teachers do?

1. Observe changes over time and consider the context.
2. Speak privately and respectfully with the student.
3. Ask open questions, such as, “I've noticed things seem different lately. How are you doing?”
4. Record factual observations in accordance with school policy.
5. Consult the appropriate school support professional and communicate with caregivers when appropriate.
6. Follow safeguarding procedures promptly if there are concerns about abuse, self-harm, or immediate safety.

Teacher reflection

What change have I noticed?

When did it begin, and what support have I offered?

Who should I consult according to school procedures?

Remember: The purpose of observation is to understand and support the student, not to label, diagnose, or make assumptions.

For professional educational use. Follow school confidentiality, safeguarding, and referral policies. Avoid recording unnecessary identifying or sensitive information.